

Orsa & Winston



DAVID SHAW
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CHAWANMUSHI

Japanese egg custard | special dashi | Hijiki seaweed
Tonburi “land caviar” | chrysanthemum | chili

CRUDO

Kanpachi crudo | Royal Corona white bean
Arugula | black radish | black sesame | green salsa sauce

VEGETABLE

Lemon cucumber | squash ribbons | sugar snap peas
shaved pecorino | hazelnut | creme fraiche with caviar | red veined sorrel | Pink lady apple
Squash blossom tempura stuffed with ricotta cheese | charred okra

KINMEDAI

Grilled Kinmedai fish | Matsutake | Matsutake soup with oregano

AGNOLOTTI

Corn Agnolotti with baby corn, ricotta, mascarpone, and pecorino
Japanese Momotaro tomato | Sungold tomato | baked basil | Sicilian black olive
Moliterno al Tartufo Nero

TEMPURA

Soft shell crab tempura | Dapple Dandy pluot | Jimmy Nardello pepper sauce

STURGEON

Grilled sturgeon | Chantelle mushroom | big fin squid | huckleberry
Japanese sweet potato puree | grapefruit butter sauce
Paired with corn pancake with grape | maple sauce | nori butter

GRANITA

Melon and Yuzu Granita

PEACH

Peach | Cinnamon sablé | cream
miso caramel sauce | pecan



When I received the notification that my Wednesday night class was canceled, I swiftly seized the opportunity to make a reservation for two at

Orsa & Winston. This restaurant had piqued my interest long before I moved to Los Angeles. My typical Wednesday evenings involve attending a two-hour lecture at the library, with no possibility of dinner before eight.

With the class canceled, we eager to explore some part of the downtown area that we've never been to. Shortly after our tour to the Broad museum,

we show up at the front door of this cozy diner. This is a small establishment with an inconspicuous entrance on a quiet street. The door

cracks open at five, only three parties have been booked, leaving me uncertain if it's the weekday or a fading popularity that's to blame. Seeing half of the space empty, I begin to ponder whether the dinner anticipated an atmosphere devoid of fervor.



Soon after comforting us on the window-side sofa, the amuse-bouche arrives at the table. “Oh no, not chawanmushi again,” I was screaming inside as the dish's name was announced. We find ourselves in a post-chawanmushi era, where this iconic Japanese creation has woven its tapestry into the fabric of fine dining across the globe. Yet, one bite tells a

different tale. Everything in this petite chawan is authentically Japanese, but the melange tastes anything but traditional. The egg custard per se tends to lean more towards an Italian flavor profile due to the absence of dashi, which typically imparts umami from kombu and katsuobushi. Here,

hijiki seaweed replaces shimeji mushrooms, tonburi takes the stage of caviar, and a subtle hint of chili powder adds a fiery undertone, rendering this dish truly one of a kind.

The first course on the tasting menu soon ensues to appear on the table. The Kanpachi crudo, with its Italian name, is escorted by a duo of royal Corona white beans and arugula, further garnished with black radish, black sesame, green salsa sauce, as well as some delicate marigold petals. The Kanpachi itself may not be as fresh and high-quality as one would expect from a prestigious Japanese restaurant, yet it pairs harmoniously with the astringent condiments. Carrying a sharper tone that surpasses all other radishes, the black radish plays an essential role here, providing a refreshing succulent texture heightened by sharp spiciness and bitterness. The arugula adds yet another layer of bitterness and sharp, peppery notes, though milder. Everything is encapsulated in a luscious layer of green salsa sauce, which serves as the primary source of acidity, bestowing the crudo with a bright, mouth-watering flavor profile. The Corona white bean, celebrated for its substantial size, offers a creamy contrast that soothes the palate.

The crudo course is followed by a salad dish in a similar yet altered manner. If we avoid overvaluing the fish, the crudo dish is essentially a salad. However, the actual salad course here is much more intricate. Despite its somewhat chaotic plating, the dish boasts two essential anchors, reminiscent of a celestial dance between twin stars. On one side, we find the raw vegetables commonly seen in Western salad dishes, including lemon cucumber, squash ribbons, and sugar snap peas. On the other side, there are elaborately cooked vegetables that proudly declare their Japanese origin. The okra is charred to perfect dryness, which not only balances the juiciness of the raw components but also introduces a mesmerizing smoky undertone. The tempura from the same culinary camp is even more astounding. The squash blossom is enveloped in a tempura coating as light as air, yet it retains a satisfying crunch and full flavor. When the tempura coating meets the hot oil, it steams the squash blossom instead of frying it, resulting in a delightful tenderness. The tempura is further stuffed with ricotta cheese, adding a final touch of creamy lightness to the medley. This complex salad is accompanied by a symphony of condiments: shaved pecorino and crème fraîche with caviar for a brilliant, pungent creaminess, hazelnuts for rich nuttiness, red-veined sorrel for a touch of citrusy aroma, and Pink Lady apple for a fruity mellowness.





Up to this point, my concern has finally been eliminated. The first few dishes may appear mundane, yet the fascinating designs the chef has injected into them elevate them beyond their superficial ordinariness.

Regrettably, the next complimentary dish gives me a painful strike. Featuring two of the most hailed Japanese ingredients, the dish showcases a tiny piece of grilled Kinmedai bathing in matsutake soup. However, this creation falls short of expectations. The Kinmedai is dreadfully overcooked, resulting in an unpleasantly rubbery mouthfeel. The matsutake soup, strangely accented with herbs, mutes the natural umami of the matsutake, further diminishing the dish's appeal.

Luckily enough, the next two dishes represent the apex of the degustation journey. The first is a highly anticipated pasta dish that celebrates the marriage of corn Agnolotti and a trio of cheeses: ricotta, mascarpone, and pecorino. The Agnolotti, crafted from corn pasta dough, envelop this cheesy trio, and they're accompanied by a delightful ensemble of Japanese Momotaro and Sungold tomatoes, baked basil, Sicilian black olives. A final shower of Moliterno al Tartufo Nero cheese bestows the medley a crowning touch of earthy aroma and extravagant creaminess. The second dish is another complimentary course, its arrival somewhat foreshadowed by the server indeliberately during the salad course. However, I'm once again taken aback by the exquisite creation. While the tempura element is a fine piece of culinary craftsmanship and the soft crab is divine, what truly shines are the paired Dapple Dandy pluot and Jimmy Nardello pepper sauce. A hybrid fruit that is a cross between a plum and an apricot, the pluot shows an unparalleled mellow sweetness. The rare Jimmy Nardello pepper, which is completely not spicy, further evokes a subdued vegetal and earthy yet well-rounded mellow sweetness.



As we savor the lingering pleasure of the tempura, our palates eagerly anticipate the final savory course. My surprise is palpable when I discover a sturgeon filet on the plate. Sturgeon is often regarded as an unwelcome fish due to its firm and chewy texture. However, it possesses a unique taste that leans more toward meat than seafood. The dish comprises a small portion of sturgeon, accompanied by grilled Chantelle mushrooms, big fin squid, and huckleberries, all bathed in a mesmerizing Japanese sweet potato puree and grapefruit butter sauce. The grilled sturgeon flesh reminds me of an overcooked chicken breast, and there's simply no remedy for its texture, which is a significant drawback of the dish. Nonetheless, the grilling process bestows the flesh with a delightful smoky aroma that harmonizes beautifully with the Chantelle mushroom. The big fin squid contributes an additional layer of oceanic flavor, filling the gap left by the sturgeon. The Japanese sweet potato puree boasts a creamy, starchy texture enriched with a well-rounded, mellow sweetness and hints of earthy and nutty undertones. This luscious flavor profile is complemented by the grapefruit butter sauce, which shares a similar silky texture but introduces a sharp acidity, akin to a refreshing breeze for the entire medley.

The main course is accompanied by a corn pancake, serving as an alternative to traditional bread. This corn pancake is uniquely embedded with grapes and generously drenched in a luscious maple sauce. On top, a quenelle of nori butter adds a distinctive touch of Japanese fusion to this otherwise quintessential American dish. By utilizing one of the oldest crops of native North Americans, the pancake exudes a rustic yet pristine character. Paired with the inclusion of berries and sweet potato in the main dish, this duo gives the impression of a hearty brunch option rather than a typical dinner menu entrée.





We soon realize that the dinner has reached its conclusion as the palate cleanser is served. This simple melon and yuzu granita proves to be refreshing but might come across as a bit too icy and harsh-textured on the palate. A smoother transition would have been a better choice here. Then, the final dessert promptly makes its appearance on the table. This dessert features peach covered with cinnamon sablé and generously capped with cream, drizzled with miso caramel sauce, and garnished with pecans. It's a dessert that places a strong emphasis on the fruit, which is a characteristic of traditional Japanese cuisine that often showcases high-quality, luxurious fruits. The addition of cinnamon sablé and cream, however, lends it the charm of a peach pie. The dinner concludes with a small chocolate biscuit presented alongside the bill, but it fails to leave any lasting impression. The finale of the dinner may appear somewhat anticlimactic overall, but the peach dessert remains a reliably satisfying choice.



The overall experience at Orsa & Winston is fabulous. A five-course dinner for a mere \$125 is not just a treasure but a rare gem to behold, not to mention the five additional courses of high-quality that come at no extra cost. The service is not necessarily flawless but does indeed exhibit professional finesse. The maitre d' stands out as both willing and capable of addressing all my inquiries about the ingredients, and, on occasion, he employs humor to ease the formality of the dinner.